FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Around this time, every year, over 10 million students in India who have just passed out of high school make a frantic search for the college of their choice. The world they are about to enter carries a set of unknown possibilities for them, and they often have no route map for it. Nor is it a static world. College education is exploding with dynamism at every level, gaining volume and complexity by the year. For instance: according to official estimates released in January 2023, there were 43.3 million young Indians enrolled in higher education institutions in the country in 2021-22, an increase of 26.5 per cent over 2014-15. Of these, close to 35 million were at the undergraduate level. Those who seek admission into these portals face what can seem to them like a bewildering profusion of choices. At last count, there were 45,473 colleges—that's nearly 7,000 more than the figure for 2014-15. At the same time, this may still mask a scarcity in specific choices when judged in terms of quality and other criteria like location. A good handbook is therefore an essential aid for every aspiring college student. This special issue gives you exactly that. In fact, the gold standard in the business.

In our 28th year now, the India Today Best Colleges Survey brings scale and experience to the table like no one else does. It has become a barometer of excellence across 14 major streams: Arts, Science, Commerce, Engineering, Medicine, Law, Architecture, Social Work, Business Administration, Dentistry, Fashion Design, Hotel Management, Mass Communication and Computer Applications. Since 2018, the survey is being conducted by the Delhi-based Marketing & Development Research Associates (MDRA). Along with MDRA, we have not only refined our methodology over the years, we have also been consistently expanding the scale of operations. The number of participating colleges has nearly doubled in the past six years—from 988 in 2018 to 1,779 this year. The survey now measures the performance of colleges on five major parameters: intake quality & governance, academic excellence, infrastructure & living experience, personality & leadership development and career progression & placement.



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While what is good and rock-solid about our survey stays intact, we have over the years thought of ways to equip the prospective college student with a more detailed GPS system, so to speak. This is to help admission-seekers and even their parents navigate through the traffic unerringly. For instance, we have made it easier for aspirants to look at which city offers them the best choice and even provided information such as which of the colleges offers the best return on investment, campus placement with the highest salary and the lowest fees. At a time when colleges across the board are innovating with course design, our survey too introduced a new feature last year. We realised that a good overall ranking for a college may be partly deceptive if you take a more close-up, well-grained view. It may not be the best one for a specific subject. Another college with more modest ratings overall may boast the best faculty in that domain—as also research and technological resources or industry tie-ups, as the case may be. These become vital if you are considering a specific course with a clear purpose in mind: a purely educational one that gels with your future research goals, or a path related to what you wish to explore as a career option. So, as a beginning, we have rated the best colleges in 12 individual subjects under two streams, Arts and Science—Economics, History, English, Psychology, Sociology, Political Science, Physics, Chemistry, Botany, Zoology, Hindi and Sanskrit.

We have also kept pace with the horizontal expansion in higher education spaces in India, and it is no surprise to find that reflected in our survey results. Colleges from cities such as Bhopal, Kanpur and Lucknow are finding place among the Top 30, showing how education is gradually getting democratised. To organise all this information in a more practically useful way, the survey lists the top three colleges in multiple Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities in the country, making it the most inclusive ranking of institutes of higher education. This feature can appeal to a variety of students. College education has a very strong legacy component. For instance, Delhi remains the hub of higher education in India, with the most colleges among the Top 10, Top 25 and Top 50 across all streams. But paradoxically, it is also a place where a vast number of students find their access choked off with unreal cutoffs. Another city or state may have an utter dearth of colleges. Karnataka, by contrast, leads all states in terms of college density, with 62 colleges for every 100,000 people aged between 18 and 23.

This unevenness is not a problem in times marked ever more by easier inter-city mobility. In fact, it offers solutions. No longer are students stuck with colleges in their own location, and they can now scout a variety of new locations, especially if they wish to pursue a specialisation at the undergraduate level. So choice has increased, and it is of paramount importance that you can cross-check your wish list against accurate grading done on a reliable system of evaluation. That is what the following pages contain.

What the survey reveals is that there is great stability around the core because of legacy institutions: the list of winners across all streams has remained unaltered for the past five years. But their continuance in their numero uno position is not just a matter of entrenched legacy. All these institutions have kept up an unwavering focus on embracing change and applying innovation in the process of learning. This is critical as higher education tries to align itself better with industry needs, that too at a time when joblessness is a big issue. India needs to ensure we don't respond to the jobs crisis merely through volumes. Keeping a national commitment to quality is vital.

This can be a time of anxiety and confusion for students and parents. But it is important to remember choices should be made on the basis of reliable information, and what you are holding in your hands is just that.

Our best wishes go out to this year's millions. Choose well because this probably is one of the most important choices you make in your life.

(Aroon Purie)